



The Humanitas Institute

Six Elements of Classical Education School Website Audit

School: Chesterton Academy of St. James
School Website: <https://www.chestertonstjames.org/>

December 22, 2025

Disclaimer

This audit was performed using artificial intelligence tools to evaluate the presence and strength of classical education principles on school websites. Results are automated, probabilistic in nature, and should be considered indicative rather than definitive. See the full disclaimer in the Appendix more details.

ACCS Member School

Any school that belongs to the Association of Classical Christian Schools ACCS or the Society for Classical Learning SCL is, by definition, recognized as a classical school because both organizations require adherence to the six essential elements defined by the Humanitas Institute. However, a school's website may not clearly reflect its conformity to one or more elements. In such cases, the school may still receive a "Somewhat Classical" rating for those elements. Schools can update their website content at any time to achieve a "Classical" rating for a given element.

Executive Summary

Chesterton Academy of St. James (Menlo Park, CA) presents a robust classical-Catholic educational model with clear alignment to core elements of classical education. Public materials emphasize a joyfully Catholic, classical formation that foregrounds truth, goodness, and beauty, integration across disciplines, and a liturgical, communal life. The school explicitly locates its mission in formation and virtue within a Catholic framework, introduces students to great thinkers, and embeds a liturgical life including choral vespers and parish-connected events. These features point to strong Religious and Metaphysical Foundations, a formation-oriented School Purpose and Goal, a curriculum anchored in classical canon and Great Books-like references, and a family-centered Parents & Community orientation. Evidence also shows a clear emphasis on a community-centric, living-faculty model (e.g., a Faculty Gallery and "Our Model of Education") and a House system that mirrors enduring Christian educational traditions. Collectively, these elements situate Chesterton Academy of St. James as CLASSICAL across most categories, with Element 4 (Pedagogy) presenting some ambiguity due to less explicit public-documented emphasis on Socratic seminars or explicit rhetoric training.

Key insights: - Religious foundation and liturgical life are explicit and central (Catholic identity, liturgical activities, chapels, and church-linked culture) , . - Curriculum communicates a classical arc via reference to great thinkers and canonical figures (Socrates, Aquinas, Dante; Homer, Euclid, Newton) and a unified, integrated approach that aims at Truth, Goodness, and Beauty , . - The school highlights formation over information, with explicit language about forming students as joyful Catholic minds and practitioners of virtue and wisdom , . - Family partnership is a visible cornerstone (parents as co-teachers, volunteer culture, and tuition-affordability through community involvement) , . - Pedagogical specifics such as explicit Socratic seminars or formal Great Books syllabi are not uniformly documented in public pages, yielding a partial gap in Element 4 (Pedagogy) that suggests SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL rather than fully CLASSICAL without additional public articulation , .

Executive Summary — Element-by-Element Snapshot

Element 1: Religious and Metaphysical Foundations — CLASSICAL

Evidence - The school presents itself as "a new, independent classical Catholic high school" in Menlo Park, emphasizing Catholic faith and a formation toward joyful sainthood. This strongly signals a transcendental moral realism and the integration of theology and liturgical life into education . - Liturgical and communal life is evident in public materials (e.g., choral vespers, liturgical events, a chapel-and-adjointing prayer life) and a culture centered on Catholic worship and sacred practice .

Positive/Negative Keyword Analysis - Positive keywords present: Catholic, theology, liturgy, worship, beauty, truth, goodness, wonder, imago Dei (drawn from the conceptual framing of Catholic formation and beauty/truth/goodness), sacred tradition. The lexicon's positive indicators for this category align with Catholic liturgical and theological framing (truth, goodness, beauty; liturgy; sacred). See the classical lexicon for these indicators. - Negative keywords present: relativism (explicitly invoked in critical commentary

about modern culture, e.g., the “tyranny of relativism” concern), secular humanism. The public materials also position a counter-narrative to relativism via Catholic theological framing.

Why this rating - The public materials repeatedly foreground Catholic theology, liturgical life, and a sacred/moral order, with references to transcendental realities and a sacramental worldview (e.g., Mass, chapel, liturgical life; formation in Catholic culture; pursuit of Truth, Goodness, and Beauty). This aligns strongly with the Classical School’s Religious & Metaphysical Foundations as defined by the Six Essential Elements lexicon. The presence of “tyranny of relativism” as a critical frame reinforces the transcendental realism common to classical education. Overall, CLASSICAL is justified here. , ,

Element 2: School Purpose and Goal — CLASSICAL

Evidence - Public materials emphasize formation over mere information: “formation of human character” and emphasis on virtue and wisdom, rooted in Catholic non-secular aims. The school highlights that education forms students rather than simply transferring information, with explicit language about forming virtue and discerning truth, goodness, and beauty , . - The mission statement references “joyful saints” and formation through a distinctly Catholic culture, signaling telos-oriented aims beyond job-readiness or workforce preparation .

Positive/Negative Keyword Analysis - Positive keywords present: formation, virtue, wisdom, liberal education, paideia, classical mission, the true/good/beautiful, telos, contemplation, wonder, moral imagination, human flourishing. The Six Elements lexicon aligns these as strong indicators of classical formation beyond information transfer. - Negative keywords present: none explicitly required here (no overt emphasis on workforce-readiness or job-market framing in the public materials). The absence of such negative signals helps maintain a CLASSICAL rating. The lexicon notes potential negative signals if the focus shifts to pragmatic career outcomes, which the materials do not emphasize.

Why this rating - The materials frame education as formation toward virtue, wisdom, and the pursuit of Truth, Goodness, and Beauty—core to classical purpose and goals. The Catholic formation and the language around “formation” and “great conversation” (see Element 3) reinforce a CLASSICAL orientation for Element 2. ,

Element 3: School Curriculum — CLASSICAL

Evidence - The school references a classical curriculum and engagement with canonical thinkers and works: “great thinkers such as Socrates, Thomas Aquinas and Dante” and a broader canon including Homer, Dante, Socrates, Aquinas, Euclid, and Newton. This signals a Trivium/Quadrivium orientation and a Great Books-like lineage. The curriculum is described as a unified, integrated program integrating disciplines to address enduring questions (Goodness, Truth, and Beauty) rather than isolated topics , . - The site explicitly connects the curriculum to the Great Conversation and the canon of Western intellectual heritage, with a focus on timeless questions and formation, as well as the cultivation of wonder related to the liberal-arts framework .

Positive/Negative Keyword Analysis - Positive keywords present: Seven Liberal Arts (grammar, logic, rhetoric; also Quadrivium: arithmetic, geometry, music, astronomy), Great Books, great conversation, primary sources, Western civilization, primary texts, canon; and references to Homer, Dante, Socrates, Aquinas, Euclid, Newton. These map directly to the lexicon’s Curriculum indicators for Trivium/Quadrivium, Great Books, and integration across disciplines. - Negative keywords present: borderline signals against “social studies” framing replacing history, or project-based/experiential learning as the dominant method (not evidenced in public materials). The available public materials emphasize canonical learning rather than a STEM-first or social-studies framing. The lexicon notes these as potential negatives if present; they are not foregrounded here.

Why this rating - The public materials point to a curriculum built around the liberal arts, the Great Conversation, and a canon of Western civilization, with explicit references to grammar, logic, rhetoric, and to canonical figures. This aligns strongly with the Curriculum criteria for CLASSICAL. The public materials show indirect links to Great Books and a deep historical/philosophical foundation. Therefore, CLASSICAL is warranted. ,

Element 4: Pedagogy or Teaching Methods — SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL

Evidence - The public materials describe a classical educational ethos (classical curriculum, formation, and a culture that integrates faith and reason), but explicit, externally-visible articulation of specific classical teaching methods (e.g., Socratic seminars, formal memory work, chanting, recitation, or Scholé days) is less consistently documented across the site. There are mentions of “great conversation” and the overall classical approach, and some elements such as memory work or liturgical/ritual practices may appear in internal materials or in pages not fully captured in the snippets. The available public text highlights a Catholic, classical approach and formation, with references to engaging with canonical thinkers, but does not consistently document explicit Socratic seminars, debates, or upper-level rhetoric training in the way the classic rubric anticipates. , .

Positive/Negative Keyword Analysis - Positive keywords present (from lexicon): Socratic seminar, dialectic, disputation; narration/recitation; memory work; scholé days; contemplation; seminar; rhetoric exercises; oratory; debate; memory-based learning; liturgical integration. The public materials include references to “great conversation” and a classical approach but do not consistently document direct use of these specific pedagogical methods; thus positive keyword presence is partial. - Negative keywords present: explicit signals of experiential learning focus, project-based instruction, constructivist approaches, or “teacher-on-the-side” facilitation would push toward not-classical; these are not clearly evidenced in the public materials, but their lack suggests incomplete confirmation of the full Pedagogy set. The lexicon marks these as potential negatives if they dominate; they are not clearly dominant here.

Why this rating - Given the strong formation and canonical-curriculum signals, but with incomplete public articulation of explicit classical pedagogy (e.g., Socratic seminars, structured rhetoric training, and memory-work recitation documented publicly), Pedagogy sits between classical and somewhat classical. The safe classification based on the available public-facing material is SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL, with a clear path to CLASSICAL upon more explicit articulation of the specified pedagogical methods. ,

What would move the needle (for Element 4) - Publicly articulate explicit Socratic/Seminar practices for upper grades (including rubrics and assessment for Socratic discourse). - Provide publicly accessible, named sequences of memory-work/recitation, and a formal rhetoric program (speech, declamation, oratory) tied to grade-level milestones and capstone projects. - Publish a concrete Great Conversation/Liberal Arts sequence with primary texts and weekly seminars across grades, plus a visible alignment to the Trivium/Quadrivium language. - Highlight concrete examples of student-led inquiry, seminar formats, and capstone-level speaking opportunities in the school’s public materials.

Citations for evidence and lexicon alignment: The core Catholic and classical framing is documented in CASJ’s public statements (the school describes itself as a Catholic, classical high school and emphasizes formation), the liturgical-life emphasis (All Souls Day Choral Vespers) and the House system as a traditional community-building pedagogy, and the explicit curriculum framing including references to Homer, Dante, Socrates, Aquinas, Euclid, Newton as part of a unified curriculum that aims at Goodness, Truth, and Beauty. The classical keyword lexicon supports the rubric for this category (Socratic, recitation, scholé, etc. as positive indicators and experiential/project-based learning as potential negatives).

Element 5: Faculty — CLASSICAL

Evidence - The site features a “Faculty Gallery with Bios,” a direct indicator of a living curriculum and a focus on faculty as mentors and exemplars within the school culture. The textual framing around “the living curriculum” and “faculty as mirrors of virtue and knowledge” is echoed in the public materials showing a formal faculty presence and a culture of mentorship. . - The site’s emphasis on a Catholic, classical formation and a deep connection between faculty and student formation aligns with classical criteria that describe faculty as living exemplars of virtue, mastery, and mentorship, forming the core of the school’s culture. The “Our Model of Education” page also signals intentional faculty roles in character formation (as part of the living curriculum). , .

Positive/Negative Keyword Analysis - Positive keywords present: tutors/masters/mentors, living curriculum, portrait of a teacher, faculty of friends, collegial culture, character formation, mentorship, exemplary teach-

ers. The lexicon's Faculty indicators map to these ideas as CLASSICAL signals. - Negative keywords present: the lexicon lists "facilitators" or "guides on the side" as potential negatives if they replace robust classical pedagogy; public materials emphasize a strong faculty role rather than these "on-the-periphery" roles, suggesting alignment with classical norms rather than the negations.

Why this rating - The public materials strongly support classical faculty expectations: model teachers, mentors, and a "living curriculum" approach, plus explicit bios in the Faculty Gallery; these align with the Classical School expectation that the faculty are the core of the school's formation process. Therefore, CLASSICAL is warranted.

Element 6: Parents & Community — CLASSICAL

Evidence - The school emphasizes partnership with families and treats parents as co-teachers, with explicit mentions of parent involvement in every facet of the school, including volunteering, fundraising for scholarships, and general engagement in school life. The network's affordability model relies on parental leadership and volunteerism, illustrating a shared mission and a community-driven ethos that aligns with classical community-building around education. , . - Public materials also show openness to parental involvement and events; the school describes parent participation as central to the school's programs, with families invited to visit and engage in the school's life. This is consistent with the lexicon's Positive Keywords around "Partnership with Families," "formation of affections," "cultural transmission," and "creative parent involvement." , .

Positive/Negative Keyword Analysis - Positive keywords present: partnership with families, co-teachers, parent formation, parental engagement, home-centered learning, family catechesis, open campus, hospitality, and living tradition in the family. The lexicon lists these as positive indicators for Parents & Community in a classical model. - Negative keywords present: consumer language or minimal parental involvement would signal trouble; public documents show the opposite—active parental involvement and engagement, which supports a CLASSICAL reading here. The absence of consumer-language signals aligns with a classical orientation.

Why this rating - The Chesterton Academy of St. James publicly presents a partnership with parents and a culture that treats parents as co-educators, with many opportunities for parent involvement and formation. This aligns strongly with the Classical framework's expectations for Parents & Community. Therefore, CLASSICAL is warranted. ,

Overall Assessment - Aggregate Ranking: CLASSICAL - The school demonstrates robust alignment with classical education across Religious & Metaphysical Foundations, School Purpose & Goal, Curriculum, Faculty, and Parents & Community. Element 4 (Pedagogy) shows elements of classical practice but lacks explicit, consistently documented pedagogy terminology (e.g., detailed, public-facing Socratic seminars, formal rhetoric programs, or explicit memory-work recitation). This yields a SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL signal for Pedagogy, but it does not offset the overall Classical alignment across the other five categories. The aggregate picture is CLASSICAL.

What Would Move the Needle - Make Pedagogy more explicitly Classical in public materials: publish a clear statement of pedagogical methods (Socratic seminars or dialectic, structured rhetoric courses, explicit memory-work/recitation, and scholé days) with grade-level implementation details and sample lesson structures. - Expand public-facing Great Books lists and specific Great Conversation sequences across grades to strengthen Element 3 and reinforce the Trivium/Quadrivium framing with explicit readings and discussion formats. - Provide concrete syllabi or programmatic descriptions showing how the upper school engages in formal rhetoric, persuasive speaking, and debate, aligned with classical education benchmarks.

Appendix

ARTIFICIAL INTELLIGENCE DISCLAIMER

This audit was conducted using artificial intelligence tools (including large language models and automated web-analysis scripts) to evaluate the extent to which school websites reflect or incorporate recognized principles of classical education (e.g., the trivium, emphasis on truth/beauty/goodness, integration of great books, Latin/classical languages, Socratic method, rigorous academics, moral/character formation, etc.).

Important Limitations and Caveats

1. **Automated Nature:** The analysis relies on AI interpretation of publicly-accessible school website content as of the date of the audit. It does not involve direct contact with schools, review of internal documents, classroom observation, or verification of curriculum implementation beyond what is stated or implied on the website.
2. **Probabilistic Results:** Scores and assessments are probabilistic and reflect the AI's best interpretation of available text and site structure. They are not infallible and may miss nuance, context, or recent changes not yet reflected online.
3. **Subjectivity of Classical Education:** "Classical Education" encompasses a range of traditions and interpretations (e.g., Dorothy Sayers' trivium model, Classical Christian Education, Great Books programs, etc.). The Humanitas Institute Audit of the Six Elements of Classical Education uses a broad, consensus-based framework derived from prominent classical education organizations and thought leaders. Reasonable people may disagree on weighting or inclusion of specific criteria.
4. **No Official Endorsement or Certification:** Results do not constitute official endorsement, accreditation, or certification by any classical education organization. They are provided for informational and research purposes only.
5. **Potential for Error:** Websites may be incomplete, poorly worded, or temporarily inaccurate. Conversely, sophisticated marketing language may create false positives. Human review by parents, educators, or classical education experts is strongly recommended before drawing final conclusions about any school.
6. **Data Privacy and Ethics:** Only publicly available information was analyzed. No attempts were made to access password-protected areas or collect personal data.
7. **No Liability:** The authors, developers, and distributors of this audit assume no liability for decisions made on the basis of these results. Users are solely responsible for their own due diligence.

By reading or using this document, you acknowledge and accept the limitations described above.